Backlog Item Anatomy

What a good epic, feature and story look like, with one running example from big bet to thin slice.

Break Down Work · Epics, Features & Stories · INVEST (Bill Wake) · Given / When / Then

HOW TO READ IT

✓ Good example, and why it works

✕ Weak example, and what's wrong

RUNNING EXAMPLE *An online grocery service wants more customers to come back and order again. Follow it down the levels.*

1 Epic

THE BIG BET

A big bet that should deliver a business outcome. Broken into features.

WEEKS TO MONTHS · OFTEN SEVERAL TEAMS

TEMPLATE

We believe [doing this] for [these people] will achieve [this outcome]. We'll know we're right when [measure].

✓ GOOD · Reorder made easy

We believe making it quick to repeat a past order, for returning customers, will increase repeat orders. We'll know when weekly repeat orders rise from 22% to 30% in 3 months.

Names the people, the outcome and a measure, so it can be proven wrong.

✗ WEAK · Reorder platform

"Build the new reorder platform."

A solution, not an outcome. No measure, so nobody can tell if it worked, or when to stop.

2 Feature

A USABLE CAPABILITY

Something users can see and use that delivers part of the epic's value.

A FEW ITERATIONS · ONE OR TWO TEAMS

TEMPLATE

[Capability] so that [benefit].

✓ GOOD · One-tap reorder

One-tap reorder of a past basket, so returning customers can repeat a weekly shop in under a minute.

Usable on its own, with a clear benefit to a named user.

✗ WEAK · Reorder back end

"Reorder API and database changes."

A technical layer. Nobody can use it alone, so it delivers no value until everything else is done.

3 Story

A THIN VERTICAL SLICE

A thin, vertical slice of a feature that a user can use. Finishes in days.

DAYS · WITHIN YOUR SLE · ONE TEAM

TEMPLATE

As a [type of user], I want [goal] so that [reason].

+ acceptance criteria: Given · When · Then

INVEST Independent · Negotiable · Valuable · Estimable · Small · Testable

✓ GOOD · SEE MY LAST ORDER

As a returning customer, I want to see my last order on the home page so that I can reorder it quickly.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

Given I've ordered before, when I open the app,
then I see my last order with a Reorder button.
Given an item is out of stock, when I reorder,
then I'm offered a substitute.

Valuable to a user, small, and testable from the criteria.

✗ WEAK · TECHNICAL TASK

"As a developer, I want a reorder table so that the data is stored."

No user value. It's a task inside a real story.

✗ WEAK · TOO BIG

"As a customer, I want to reorder, edit my basket and schedule delivery."

Three stories joined by "and". Split it (see Story Splitting).

TASK

A step the team takes to finish a story.
Not tracked as value.

SPIKE

Time-boxed research to answer a question.
Its output is knowledge.

BUG

Doesn't work as agreed.
Fix fast, or order it like any other item.

ENABLER

Technical work that makes future value possible, such as paying down debt.

"Who is this for, and what will be better for them?"

"Could a user use this slice on its own?"

© 2026 Eric Parker · CC BY 4.0 · eparker71.github.io/better-delivery-toolkit